



‘What’s in it for me?’ – Contrasting environmental organisations and forest owner participation as policies evolve[☆]

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ABSTRACT

Stakeholder participation in forest policy processes has over years received political and scientific attention. This empirical study brings in a dynamic element, exploring how and why participation change as policies evolve. Two Norwegian policy cases serve to contrast participation by environmental organisations (ENGOS) and forest owner organisations (FOs) over time. The policy arrangement approach (PAA) is used as analytical framework, first, to explore changes in coalitions, rules of game, power constellations, and discourses for each of the policy cases. Second, an initial exploration is offered on how changes in the PAA dimensions affect the assessments of ‘what’s in it for me’ for ENGOS versus FOs. The results indicate that when standards for sustainable forest management are implemented, the value for ENGOS to participate in standard revision is decreasing, while in forest protection, the ENGOS chose to participate in a coalition requesting more money for voluntary protection, even after being excluded from identifying interesting areas for protection. Combining evolving policies and participation based on ‘what’s in it for me’ help explain why participation changes over time. The findings provide alternative perspectives on former work presenting continued participation as a challenge and important messages related to future forest policy analysis.

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1. Introduction

Stakeholder participation in forest policy processes has over years received political and scientific attention. While participation have long traditions in Nordic countries, the diversity of interests among stakeholders increased as the forest objectives broadened up with the elaborations of sustainable forest management (SFM). The statement that “Forest resources and forest lands should be sustainably managed to meet the social, economic, ecological, cultural and spiritual needs of present and future generations” (UNCED, 1992; Rio Forest principles: Principles/Elements 2(b)) was followed by a recommendation that “Governments should promote and provide opportunities for the participation of interested parties, including local communities and indigenous people, industries, labor, non-governmental organizations and individuals, forest dwellers and women, in the development, implementation and planning of national forest policies” (UNCED, 1992; Rio Forest principles: Principles/Elements 2(d), United Nations, UN, 1992).

Numerous studies exist of stakeholder participation in forest policy processes, and developments described as change from government to governance. Appelstrand (2002: 281) discussed challenges for lawmakers

and policy practitioners in “finding consensus in diversity” and blending of “multiple management objectives” while highlighting the value of including lay knowledge and subjective perceptions from the public. Kangas et al. (2010) explored stakeholder perspectives on proper participation in regional forest programmes. They identified three interlinked challenges to improve participatory processes: (i) how to motivate relevant participants to contribute; (ii) how to commit to what is agreed, to avoid confusion in the group; and (iii) how to run process, so participants will consider their time spent as well worth the efforts (Kangas et al., 2010: 220). Along the same line, Faehnle and Tyrväinen (2013) state that meaningful participation, from the point of view of actors, relates to ‘what’s in it for me’. In parallel to work discussing ways to ensure and improve participation, other studies point to challenges in participation and ‘participation fatigue’. For example, Wesselink et al. (2011:2689) in natural resource management “suggest that some of the ‘participation fatigue’ can be explained by the differences in expectations regarding participation” between those involved in participatory processes and experts organising or conducting research on participation.

This empirical paper builds on these studies, and takes as a starting point that stakeholders will spend time and resources only on policy areas and processes where they consider participation meaningful. The focus in the following is on how ‘what’s in it for me’, i.e. the meaningfulness of participation in policy processes, develops as the policies evolve. Dynamic aspects of participation is investigated, contrasting involvement by environmental non-governmental organisations (ENGOS) and forest

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owners' organisations (FOs) in two forest policy processes in Norway. The overall aim is to combine empirical evidence of changing participation with broader conceptual discussions of meaningfulness of participation.

The objective is to elaborate on how and why participation change as policies evolve. Employing the policy analysis approach (PAA) (Arts et al., 2006; Leroy and Arts, 2006) as analytical framework, participation by ENGOs and FOs in two forest policy processes over time is investigated in two steps. First, changes along the four PAA dimensions: coalitions, rules of the game, discourse and power relations, are described for the two policy cases. Second, why participation changes is explored contrasting 'what's in it for me' for ENGOs and FOs respectively as the policies evolve.

The following two sections present the material and method. Next, developments in the two policy cases are described, before changing participation by ENGO and FO in different coalitions over time is elaborated in light of changes in power relations, rules of the game and discourses. Finally, the results are discussed related to former and future work and conclusions drawn.

2. Material

This study focuses on two Norwegian forest policy processes with diverse and changing participation: "Living Forests", developing standards for sustainable forest management (SFM) and "voluntary protection", a new way to protect productive forests. These cases represent two prominent aspects of forest management: protection of productive forests and sustainable management of forests, and were selected as interesting cases to explore changing participation as policies evolve. The initial exploration is restricted to two stakeholder groups, ENGOs and FOs, selected for being important players in forest policy and management in general, as well as in the two policy processes of concern. The investigations cover the processes from the start to current, highlighting changes over time.

The motivation for investigating complexity and gradual changes in participation in the two processes by ENGOs and FOs grew from the author following national and international policy developments and debates over years, and conducting interviews with multiple national stakeholder groups for another project in 2013 (reported e.g. in Peters et al., 2015; Pezdevšek Malovrh et al., 2016). Interviews with ENGOs and FOs, and broader stakeholder groups in 2013, revealed divergent opinions of the developments and collaborations between environmental and economic interests within the two policy processes. The way stakeholders described the collaborations over time, triggered the question of how and why the motivation for ENGOs versus FOs to participate in the processes changes as the policies evolve.

Empirical data for the analysis, describing developments in the two policy processes, including how participation changes, stem from a variety of written sources supplemented by interview data. Changes and developments in the two processes are taken from policy documents (e.g. Ministry of Agriculture, MoA, 1998; Ministry of Environment, MoE, 2003). Two evaluations, one of the Living Forest process and the Norwegian standards for SFM (Arnesen et al., 2004) and one of the working method of voluntary forest protection (Skjeggedal et al., 2010), as well as information from interviews among national stakeholders conducted by the author for studies on closely related topics, also provided information on the process evolutions. Furthermore, statements, letters and news coverage, a diverse range of secondary sources and participatory observations by the author of national and international forest policy processes over years have provided information on developments as well as perceptions among different actors. The cases represent divergent trends regarding stakeholder participation over time, and thus interesting cases for exploring how stakeholders with different objectives, here ENGOs and FOs, act and react at different times of developments.

Specific for the second, explorative part of the analysis, changes in 'what's in it for me' on the side of stakeholders, two semi-structured interviews were conducted for COST Action FP1207 "ORCHESTRA" Working Group 3. As for interviews conducted by the author in 2013 (see above), all interviews were conducted face-to-face using semi-structured questions. In line with the interview guide developed for Orchestra WG3, the main focus was on how the two central representatives, one from ENGO, one from FO, considered their own and other's participation, as well as their assessment of the participation over time. From the stories told by ENGO and FO (2015 interview ENGO; 2015 interview FO), respectively, on how the processes changed from a true collaboration on developing standards for sustainable forest management to revisions without ENGOs involved, and how FOs took over the role as initiating partner in processes to protect productive forests, the indirect assessments of 'what's in it for me' is constructed and elaborated in the following. The idea is that the differences between ENGOs and FOs in participation and assessment of participation over time provide an alternative perspective on the meaningfulness of participation, and that this perspective is essential for orchestrating policy analysis.

3. Method

To investigate developments in the Norwegian policy processes, the policy arrangement approach (PAA) (Arts et al., 2006; Leroy and Arts, 2006) serves as analytical framework. Leroy and Arts (2006) emphasized that the four PAA dimensions; coalitions, rules of the game, discourse and power relations, are equal sources of change and stability. Changes in any of these dimensions can lead to changes in the other: the actors involved in the policy domain, and their coalitions (including their oppositions); the division of resources between these actors, leading to differences in power and influence; the rules of the game within the policy arrangement, either in terms of formal procedures or as informal rules and 'routines' of interaction; and the policy discourses, entailing the norms and values, the definitions of problems and approaches to solutions of the actors involved.

The first step of the analysis is inspired by Arts and Buizer (2009) exploring changes in global forest governance. Developments in two national forest policy processes are investigated, focusing on changes and interactions in coalitions, rule of game, discourse and power. The dynamics in these four dimensions of policy arrangement analysis (PAA) (Arts et al., 2006) are explored, focusing on changes in participation and power as the overall policies evolve (with changing discourse and rules of the game). Following this paper's focus on participation by ENGOs and FOs – and changes therein – the involvement by these two stakeholder groups in the two processes and in related broader coalitions over time, is emphasized in the investigation. In this initial investigation, coalition(s) refer to involvement by ENGOs and FOs, respectively. Rules of the game are taken directly from the process developments, interpreted as the changes in how standards for SFM are developed and implemented as well as how productive forests are protected. Acknowledging that changing discourses and changes in power relations cannot be taken directly from any "face value", discourse is here interpreted as the common, dominant understanding of what SFM entails, while power is understood as the actors' ability to influence the policy developments.

The second step, the initial exploration of why participation changes as the policy evolves, combines developments along the four dimensions of PAA with former work stressing the importance of making participation worth the efforts (cf. e.g. Kangas et al., 2010; Faehnle and Tyrväinen, 2013). In line with the main objectives of this paper, the focus is on changing participation as policies evolve, contrasting 'what's in it for me' for ENGOs and FOs over time. This step aims at bringing the empirically based PAA results into a broader conceptual discussion of participation and policy development.

4. Results

4.1. Changes in policy arrangements

4.1.1. Case 1: standards for sustainable forest management (SFM)

4.1.1.1. Coalitions. National standards for SFM were developed as one part of the project “Living Forest”, 1995–1998 (MoA, 1998). The project was initiated by the forest sector as a response to increasing pressure and demands, also from international markets, to improve and document long-term, responsible forest management, including proper environmental considerations. The NGOs were invited to participate, and the project initially represented an innovative collaboration of economic, environmental and social interests, with 50% of the costs covered by the (at that time) Ministry of Environment and Ministry of Agriculture (Arnesen et al., 2004:7). Informants from both ENGO and FO consider the first phase, resulting in the agreement on the first set of standards in 1998, to be truly collaborative, with broad participation and consensus-based decisions (2015 interview ENGO; 2015 interview FO).

The collaboration run into trouble soon after the 1998 agreement. The NGOs were disappointed by the FOs use of the standards, and what the NGOs considered to be modifications “behind closed doors” to make the standards suitable for certification (Arnesen et al., 2004, 2015 interview ENGO). The initial plan for revision of the standards after 5 years was delayed, and when the first revision was conducted in 2006, one of the NGOs (Friends of the Earth) did not take part. At the time of the second revision (2010), all NGOs (and some of the social groups) withdrew from the process, because they were not satisfied with the progress (two years delay of returning to two of the standards), and continued disagreement on two standards (tree species acceptable for planting and questions of mapping of key biotopes). The 2015 revision of the standards was conducted with no NGOs participating.

4.1.1.2. Rules of game. The work on standards for SFM and their later use for forest certification followed the trend of market-based private governance systems emerging in the forest sector in the early 1990s (e.g. Gulbrandsen, 2014). The work is an example of the “participation of interested parties” recommended by the Rio Forest Principles (see Section 1) (United Nations, UN, 1992). The rules of the game were changed from traditional government to governance following the trend of market-based private governance systems emerging after Rio 1992, and inspired by follow-up processes in Europe (Forest Europe) and neighboring countries (Finland and Sweden).

When the standards were used for forest certification, it represented a profound change in the rules of the game for forest management. Forest certification was implemented very fast in Norway, with group certification through forest owners' organisations. According to the certification bodies, all “serious timber buyers” require timber to come from sustainably managed forest, meaning it has to be certified (Norsk skogsertifisering, 2016). This requirement implies that the use of the standards for SFM is institutionalised through forest certification. Moreover, the change in rules for how to conduct forestry is an example of change in *content*, additional to the change in *procedure* with broader participation in policy process, described above.

4.1.1.3. Discourse. With the understanding of “discourse as interpretative schemes” (Arts and Buizer, 2009:343), the discourse(s) on forest management changed gradually through different stages. Initially, before the collaboration through the Living Forest project, the NGOs and FOs had rather different perceptions of forest management, i.e. conflictive discourses existed. Through the first round of developing standards (1995–1998), a more common understanding emerged of what the situation and challenges were in forest management. An ENGO informant stated that “through collaborations and work on standards, I have a better understanding and increased sympathy for some of the challenges in

practical forest operations, for example the difficulties in fixing terrain damage from transport in cases of heavy rain” (ENGO interview 2013). Likewise, it is reasonable to assume that FOs, through the close collaboration with NGOs, learned more of the critical environmental considerations in forest management. For example, Arnesen et al. (2004:65) refer to WWF as “the knowledge producer for the biological perspective” in developing the standards for SFM. The resulting understanding of the situation and critical aspects to further improve forest management were, at the point of agreement on the standards in 1998, closer to a common perception of challenges and opportunities, and preferred management of forests, i.e. a common discourse.

In later revisions, NGOs did not participate in the coalition, because they had a competing understanding of remaining problems in forest management. The NGOs raised concern about the certification systems not working (standards not strict enough, lack of control and breaking the existing regulations) and to forest activities outside the certification scheme (e.g. fire wood collection) (ENGO interviews 2013). Still, a central NGOs representative has referred to the national standards for SFM as a success, because they are providing “minimum environmental requirements for all forest management” (Andresen, 2013).

4.1.1.4. Power relations. In the early stage of developing standards, both NGOs and FOs tried to influence the policy changes in their preferred directions. They had common interests in finding joint solutions, and thus balanced their individual power. The new discourse and rules of the game, influenced by national work as well as international trends, require regular revisions of the standards for SFM used for forest certification. The FO informant stated (2015 interview FO): “The decision on the standard revision is for those at the table. Still, we could not relax the [environmental (author remark)] requirements, we had to be careful with changes. We had honest and open discussions, including on what is possible in practice. The standards could maybe have been stronger with the NGOs at the table.” It may be argued that the power of the FOs within the process increased when the NGOs withdrew. Still, through the earlier steps, in particular through the changes in the discourse and the rule of game, the new situation that certification is required to sell timber to professional buyers, the shadow of ENGO interest remained in the process after they left the coalition. Furthermore, the comment that the standards could have been stricter with NGOs at the table, is a question of difference in degree (that the exact restrictions could have been different in a situation with NGOs participating), while certification established as routine when selling timber constitutes a greater change to the power balance, with third party monitoring the conduct in forest management.

The NGOs, on the other hand, likely possess more power by not being part of the coalition. Standing outside the process, they have the power to bring cases to the media attention, and blame and shame forest actions compared to what has been promised by the FOs.

4.1.2. Case 2: voluntary forest protection

4.1.2.1. Coalitions. Protection of more productive forests was on the political agenda in Norway from the 1980s (Framstad et al., 2002). In the traditional system for protection, environmental authorities identified areas of interest for protection and included them on a gross list of forest areas considered for protection. Biologically valuable areas were sometimes identified by NGOs, while FOs were not informed before learning that a part of their forest was interesting for protection. Areas on the gross list for protection had restrictions on forest activities, and as progress in the process to formal protection was slow, the system created a lot of conflicts (see e.g. Bergseng and Vatn, 2008). The FOs were critical about lack of information, and the (informal) coalitions between environmental authorities and NGOs at this early stage.

An evaluation of Norwegian forest protection (Framstad et al., 2002), initiated by the Ministry of Environment and the Ministry of Agriculture, pointed to low shares of protected productive forests in Norway

and recommended a considerable increase in protected productive forests (from less than 1% to minimum 4.5% of the area). This evaluation and the increasing attention in international markets and on policy agendas contributed to enhance the search for alternative ways to increase the area of protected productive forests in Norway. In 2003, the FOs initiated a pilot project on voluntary protection (MoE, 2003), which was later made permanent (Skjeggedal et al., 2010). As an alternative to “traditional” protection processes, forest owners individually or in groups offer selected areas for protection. The process is unique in establishing close coalitions between environmental authorities and FOs.

The ENGOS are critical to some of the aspects of voluntary protection process, e.g. the identification and prioritizing of areas. Still, they have over years taken part in coalitions arguing for increased funding for protection – out of which the largest share go to voluntary protection. Central ENGOS have signed letters to the prime minister, the minister of finance and the minister of climate and environment requesting more money for forest protection (e.g. *Norges Skogeierforbund et al.*, 2014). The alliance between ENGOS and FOs lobbying for more money to forest protection has been termed “an extremely rare coalition” by a Norwegian newspaper (*Aftenposten*, 2004), and the ENGO interviewees in both 2013 and 2015 voice strong support for more funding for forest protection.

4.1.2.2. Rule of the game. From environmental authorities (and sometimes ENGOS) initiating forest protection, the FOs regained control over the protection process through voluntarily offering areas for protection. If environmental authorities find the areas interesting, the area and the compensation is negotiated between individual forest owners and environmental authorities. After agreement, the proposed area for protection is sent on public hearing, also to ENGOS, in line with other types of protection, as required by the Nature Diversity Act (Ministry of Climate and Environment, MoCE, 2009). After a successful pilot testing, the voluntary protection scheme was made permanent as standard procedure, and consequently the rule of the game for forest protection were changed.

It is worth mentioning that the ENGO informant refer to the voluntary protections scheme as time and cost effective, avoiding never ending debates, and that the quality of the areas protected are acceptable (2015 interview ENGO). He is less happy with the process, especially that only FOs and environmental authorities are involved in selecting the areas. As for the standards for SFM (see above), this indicate a more negative/different assessments of the new procedure than of the content/results of the process on the side of the ENGOS.

4.1.2.3. Discourse. With discourse as interpretative scheme (cf. above, Arts and Buizer, 2009), a considerable change is revealed in the FOs perception of proper conduct, i.e. discourse. The FOs consider economic compensation for leaving environmentally valuable areas untouched as an alternative to regular forest use. This situation is similar to Finland, where Sarkki et al. (2015:14) found that “the METSO programme was able to transform the problem definitions related to biodiversity conservation by initiating voluntary protection schemes in which forest owners can offer their forests for conservation and are paid for doing so. (...) [thus] questioning the guiding assumptions regarding forest owners' attitudes towards conservation and going as far as changing the whole framework of how forest owners' rights and obligations are dealt with.” By this change in perceptions among FOs, a common understanding is developing with the ENGOS on the need for more protected forests, even if the two stakeholder groups have different opinions of how best to select areas for protection.

More generally, the use of alternative wording is an example of discursive struggle for acceptance of divergent interests and values involved. Skjeggedal et al. (2010) refer to the positioning between different actors, with the FOs winning through with “voluntary protection”, and partly also their use of “compulsory protection” about the

traditional protection scheme. Public documents now refer to “voluntary protection”, for example the Ministry of Climate and Environment presenting new areas protected (MoCE, 2015). Through the established use of ‘voluntary protection’, the concept has emerged as a mini-discourse changing how actors think about protection of forests in Norway.

4.1.2.4. Power relations. Skjeggedal et al. (2010) found that conservation organisations/ENGOS are involved less and later in the voluntary protection process – and that they have lost some power in debates of forest protection. The ENGOS are no longer involved in proposing areas for protection, and the ENGO informant state that “when areas proposed for protection is coming on public hearing, after agreement is reached between forest owner and environmental authorities, it is often too late for influencing the allocation” (2015 interview ENGO). Individual forest owners (and the FOs), on the other hand, have increased their power by having the exclusive right to propose areas to be considered for protection, direct negotiations with environmental authorities about compensation, and the mandate for final decision. A condition for the FOs to work with voluntary protection was that public authorities could not first invite forest owners to offer areas voluntarily, and next, if they did not reach agreement, there would be a risk on that the authorities would turn to “traditional protection”, and protect the area against the will of FOs (2015 interview FO).

The ENGOS are critical to the power of FOs in the process, illustrated by the ENGO interview (2015): “The forest owners are heavily involved with a lot of power and control. The environmental and social side are practically not involved.” And: “The politicians have given up their authority by being left to say ‘yes’ or ‘no’ to proposals from the forest owners. It is a *sector controlled* protection scheme” (cf. the discourse dimension above).

4.2. ‘What’s in it for me?’ – changing participation as policies evolve

Moving to the second research question, the aim is to elaborate on how changes in the four PAA dimensions, coalition, discourse, rule of game and power relations, can contribute to explain the changes in participation between ENGOS and FOs as policies evolve. As stated above, the exploration will combine described changes along the four PAA dimensions (cf. Section 4.1) with former studies stressing that stakeholders will participate where and when they can influence the policies, i.e. consider their participation meaningful (Kangas et al., 2010; Faehnle and Tyrväinen, 2013). ENGO and FO participation is thus contrasted, focusing on how their possibilities for influencing policy developments change as the policies evolve. In line with the provisional nature of the elaborations, focus is on how developments in the two cases interact with the broader policy context, and in particular dynamic aspects of participation by ENGOS and FOs within and across the policy cases.

The empirical cases, developing standards for sustainable forest management and the voluntary protection scheme, showed increasing environmental considerations and decreasing direct involvement of ENGOS over the years investigated. The ENGOS left the *coalitions*, withdrawing from revision of standards for SFM (Arnesen et al., 2004) and were excluded from the identification of areas for protection as the voluntary scheme emerged (Skjeggedal et al., 2010). The FOs continue work on standards and have a central role in forest protection.

Contrasting ENGO and FO participation in the work on standards for SFM, it seems that in the initial stage both groups had something to win by participating in the coalition. The ENGOS were seeking to change forest management in a more environmentally friendly direction, while FOs saw the need for documenting and improving environmental aspects of forest management. In the implementation, when individual forest owners and FOs are bound by the commitments, the ENGOS have less to win by participation in the coalition. The lower score on ‘what’s in it for me’ is linked, first, to that the situation is already

improved with having the standards in use (related to rules of the game, see below), and, second, to the fact that adjustments in standards are less likely to make large shifts, i.e. the difference between establishing a new system and modifying an existing system.

In forest protection, NGOs were excluded from finding areas for protection, but then choose other ways of influencing. Through participating in coalitions arguing for more money for forest protection they ensure visibility of own work, and get attention to the need for increasing protected areas. They promote their primary opinions, and rather than spending time identifying potential areas for protection, take shares in the large increases in public funding for forest protection (from 50 mill NOK annually in 2002, to a record 331 mill NOK in 2013 (Lindstad, 2015)). The FOs, on their side, through the collaboration with environmental authorities on offering areas for protection, regained power to decide on the management of their private forests.

The possibilities for NGOs to affect policies – while not being part of the coalitions – are also linked to the *new rules of the game*, with use of standards for SFM in certification and voluntary protection institutionalised. With these, the FOs are influenced by the new understanding of how forests should be managed and in their new role as providers of areas for protection. With “certification required for selling timber to serious buyers” (Norsk skogsertifisering, 2016), the FOs have self-imposed reasons to continue the work, including regular revisions of standards. Likewise, in work on voluntary protection FOs have to fulfill their part of the commitments, by continuing to provide environmentally important areas for protection. In both cases the gradual developments have had path-forming influences (Arts and Buizer, 2009) on how forest management is considered among FOs and the greater public, in ways taking care of the NGOs interests.

On paper the NGOs may have lost some *power* while from the developments described, the environmental considerations in Norwegian forest management are strengthened. With a broader perspective, it is a question if the NGOs' withdrawal (voluntary and forced) from the two case under investigation, is compensated for by their engagement in the broader developments. In forest protection, NGOs affect developments through keeping forest protection on the political agenda, in particular as a watch dog for the quality of protected areas and the annual areas protected when lobbying for more money to compensate for protection. Regarding standards for SFM, the NGOs use the established commitments to name and shame forest activities, as well as for bringing cases to court. Standing outside the process, they have more power to bring cases to the media attention, blaming/shaming in line with what has been promised earlier, checking for real improvements, and even bring what they consider violations to certification system to the court. In both cases, arguing for increased funding for protection, and using standards for naming and shaming, and bringing cases to court, the NGOs influence on forest policy and management may be as great, or greater, than when they had more prominent roles within the two processes.

Moving to *discourses*, a general reflection is that increased attention to forest protection and general environmental considerations in forest management, described in the two national cases, correspond with an emerging sustainable forest management discourse. As commented among others by Pülzl et al. (2014:388), the SFM discourse is linked to the meta-discourse of sustainable development, which is also promoting public participation. On an overall level, this points to participation as a *procedural aspects* of the SFM discourse, supplementing standards for SFM and attention to protected forests as *content parts* of the SFM discourse.

The discourse promoting participation by non-governmental organisations (i.e. both NGOs and FOs) may have been important in the initial stage of the Living Forest project developing standards for SFM. One indication of this is the economic support to the project, with 50% covered by public sources, as mentioned above (Arnesen et al., 2004:7). Also in the protection case, attention to involvement by affected parties may have contributed to a more positive attitude by environmental

authorities to greater involvement of the FOs in proposing areas for protection.

In later stages of both cases, it seems that the ENGO ideas are reflected in the new *discourses* so that their interests are taken care of without them participating in the coalitions (Den Besten et al., 2014). Through developments on both standards and protection, it is a question if the forest sectors' promises and commitments on environmental contributions, as part of the more environmentally friendly forest discourse, have created higher expectations and leave greater room for NGOs for naming, blaming and shaming (cf. e.g. Den Besten et al., 2014:41). Also, they avoid providing legitimacy to standards used for PEFC certification, a debated issue within NGOs supporting FSC certification.

5. Discussion

Summing up, the two policy cases have revealed complex changes along the four dimensions of PAA: actor coalitions, discourse, rules of game and power relations over time. The interactions between gradual development in the two policy processes, along the four dimensions of PAA, and environmental considerations over time are illustrated in Fig. 1.

The empirical cases have demonstrated that as policies evolve, the assessment on the side of the actors of ‘*what's in it for me*’, changes. What different actors can achieve by participation change as the policy processes and broader policy environment evolve. This provides an alternative perspective on changing participation, and in particular challenges in continued participation as identified e.g. by Wesselink et al. (2011), Kangas et al. (2010), and Faehnle and Tyrväinen (2013). The results indicate that as policies evolve, the FOs are bound by earlier commitments for revisions and use of standards for SFM and to offer new productive forests for protection, and thus the NGOs interests are served without them participating.

PAA was useful as analytical frame, first for a structured analysis of changes and developments in the four dimensions: coalitions, rules of game, discourse and power relations in the two policy cases, and second, for exploring why participation changes as new rules of the game are gradually institutionalised, new discourses emerging, and NGOs interests are better served by not participating in the coalitions. Recalling the provisional status of this study, it should be reiterated that the two stakeholder groups and the selected policy cases serve as examples. Simplifications are acknowledged, in contrasting only NGOs and FOs, not paying attention to divergent opinions within these groups, and for providing only a glimpse of national forest policy developments. With these limitations, the results are discussed versus former and future policy analysis.

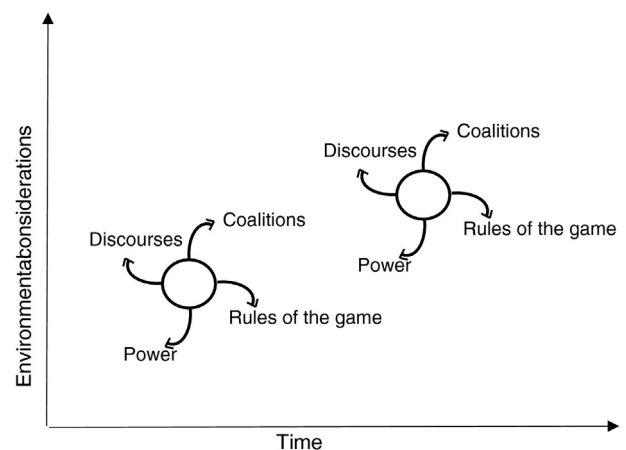


Fig. 1. Gradual developments through interactions among the four dimensions of PAA over time with increasing environmental considerations.

First, in policy documents (e.g. UN, 1992) participation is presented as an end, or objective, while for stakeholders, participation is a means to an end; to influence policy developments. This can explain why actors choose not to take part even if invited (ENGOS in standards revision) and why they choose a different level of coalition when closed out from identifying areas for protection (ENGOS participating in coalition arguing for more money to forest protection). As participation will be assessed based on 'what's in it for me', different actors will choose the level and the process giving the greatest influence on policy development at any time. This can explain 'participation fatigue' (Wessellink et al., 2011) as well as challenges in continued participation by stakeholder groups (Kangas et al., 2010; Faehnle and Tyrväinen, 2013). Policy analysts intending to orchestrate different actors, thus needs to pay attention to emerging and declining coalitions, multiple processes and alternative levels of coalitions, as well as the influence stakeholder can pursue even if not participating in coalitions.

Versus challenges described with participation, cf. Section 1, the dynamic perspective employed in this study, point to reasons for changes in participation. Different from the challenges identified by Kangas et al. (2010) this study finds that (i) the motivation to participate will change as policies evolve, (ii) actors will use the agreements/commitment in ways that best serve their own interests, creating confusion among former allies, and (iii) some of the actors will find their time and resources not worth the efforts, and will not participate. This study indicate that policy analysis acknowledging the dynamic aspects of how and why stakeholder participation changes as forest policies evolve, can provide more realistic perspectives on participation over time. Future studies need to take these aspects into account, while also including broader stakeholder groups and greater diversity in interests. Building on the current study, further details on the four dimensions of PAA and their interactions over time is recommended for future investigations.

While this study has focused on participation, a note is in place on alternative sources influencing the policy developments. In a situation with increasing environmental pressure, from ENGOS as well as in markets, the FOs could consider standards for SFM as one way to regain control over forest management. In initiating voluntary protection, aside from getting a hand on the steering wheel in proposing areas for protection, the broader question is if the FOs also saw that the increasing environmental considerations, including the standards for SFM, together with falling timber prices gradually extended the areas of forests that could not be economically utilized. In a situation of reduced economic potential in the forests, protection could be considered an alternative source of income for forest owners. Alternative sources of influence(s) also require attention in policy analysis.

The findings contribute to explain former observations (e.g. Arts, 2003), that the ENGOS often play important roles in initiating policy changes, while when the system is established, the ENGOS have less to win by continued participation. The current study indicate that these changes follow from both internal reasons: lower prospects for great changes (as long as system is established) and external factors: new issues calling for attention (Arnesen et al., 2004 pointing to ENGOS moving from standards to protection, and in own interviews: ENGOS moving to global forest challenges e.g. REDD +). Also, the gradual changes within the two policy cases in Norway, raise the question if they together could be seen as elements of spiraling to higher environmental consciousness, similar to what was revealed for REDD + (Den Besten et al., 2014). If so, the Norwegian policy cases may be seen to contribute to (any of) the existing environmental meta-discourses (Pülzl et al., 2014) where over time, new perceptions of proper behavior are institutionalised. Such a gradual strengthening of environmental requirements provide an alternative perspective on how future actions are considered in an evolving policy context.

The findings in Norway show similarities with changes in Swedish forest policies, for example that "ecological modernization had a discursive impact by introducing sustainable forest management as a viable policy alternative" (Hysing and Olsson, 2008:742). In early stages of

developments, the findings follow the Swedish case (Hysing and Olsson, 2008: 743) "reframing perceptions of policy problems and solutions, including of new priorities of ecological values and new modes of governing". Also, the later developments, with gradual withdrawal of ENGO support for work on standards resembles the developments in Sweden. Johansson (2012) found reduced ENGO support, even for FSC certification in Sweden. The reduced ENGO support in Norway and Sweden is contrary to the third phase of non-state global governance proposed by Bernstein and Cashore (2007) suggesting that with the certification system established, a third phase with shared norms would materialize. From the Norwegian cases the question for future research is how ENGOS and FOs use former commitments to strengthen their own standing, including how ENGOS will use standards and FOs promises when complaining about concrete actions, by naming, shaming and legal actions.

6. Conclusions

The analysis has revealed substantive changes in the understanding of how forests should be managed and the way the stakeholders work together. The Norwegian cases thus represent national examples of gradual emerging "new social practices on forests in the course of time" as revealed at global level by Arts and Buizer (2009:346). Overall, the empirical cases showed a decreasing involvement of ENGOS over time, an apparent contradiction in decreasing ENGO involvement and increasing environmental considerations. The findings support former accounts of complexity in forest policy development and governance. The initial exploration of two policy processes focusing on ENGOS and FOs call for attention to various levels of coalitions, rules of game, discourses and power relations. From the two cases, participation in establishing new policy schemes seems to attract broader participation than modifications in existing systems. The ENGO participation in broader coalitions, arguing for more funding to forest protection and their strategic use of the standards for SFM, show how the process commitments may be used also by actors not participating in processes. The empirical cases point to changes in 'what's in it for me' for ENGOS versus FOs, and call for attention to dynamic aspects of participation, with stakeholders choosing levels and processes in response to evolving policies.

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